

MATTHEW COETZEE

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EDUCATION

University of Notre Dame

Ph.D., Sociology with Minor in Screen Cultures 2023 – Expected May 2026
Dissertation: *Rupture and Repair: Community Responses to State Failure and Racial Violence in Post-Apartheid South Africa*
Advisors: Ann Mische & Terry McDonnell

University of Notre Dame

M.A., Sociology 2021 – 2023
Thesis: *Disruptive Events, Adhocracies, and Symbolic Boundaries in Post-Apartheid South Africa: Democratic Resilience on the Fly in July 2021*
Advisors: Ann Mische & Lyn Spillman

SOAS University of London

M.S., Public Policy and Management 2019 – 2021

Yale University

B.A., Double Major in Sociology and African Studies (with Distinction) 2014 – 2018
GPA: 3.81
Sociology Thesis: *Social Networks and Structural Diversity at College: African Student Networks, Identity and Integration*
Advisor: Grace Kao
African Studies Thesis: *Robben Island: Perspectives on Dark Tourism and the Search for Authenticity*
Advisor: Philip Smith

RESEARCH AND TEACHING INTERESTS

Cultural Sociology; Theory; Qualitative Methods; Social Movements and Collective Behavior; Political Sociology; Digital Sociology; Global and Comparative Sociology.

HONORS & AWARDS

Harry Frank Guggenheim Emerging Scholars Award, <i>Guggenheim Foundation</i> , \$25,000	2025
Becker Award, Best Graduate Research Paper in Sociology, <i>University of Notre Dame</i>	2024
R.F. Thompson Award for Outstanding Research in African Studies, <i>Yale University</i>	2018
Rhodes Scholarship Finalist – Southern Africa, <i>Rhodes Trust</i>	2018

PUBLICATIONS

Peer Reviewed Publications

- 1) **Coetzee, Matthew.** 2025. "Recurating Robben Island: Cultural Objects, Digital Memory, and the Entropic Afterlives of National Heritage." *American Journal of Cultural Sociology* 13(1):1–33.

Under Review

- 2) **Coetzee, Matthew.** "Contingent Memory Activation: Collective Memory, Crisis Response, and the Dynamics of Social Action." *American Journal of Sociology*.

July 31, 2025

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Book Manuscript

- 3) Smith, Christian, **Matthew Coetzee**, and Bridget Ritz. *Re-enchanted America*. Book manuscript **under review** at Oxford University Press.

Book Chapters

- 4) Summers-Effler, Erika, **Matthew Coetzee**, Hyunjin Kwak, and Justin Van Ness. “*Mapping Social Change Efforts: A Dynamic and Integrative Four-Quadrant Framework*.” Chapter manuscript, invited submission for *Edited Volume on Culture and Social Movements*, edited by Guya Accornero and James M. Jasper.

Working Papers

Ready for Submission

- 5) Summers-Effler, Erika and **Matthew Coetzee**. “Histories in Motion: Mapping Shifts in Social Change Efforts Over Time” In preparation to be submitted to *American Sociological Review*.

Nearing Completion

- 6) **Coetzee, Matthew**. “When Meaning Acts: A Critical Realist Cultural Sociology from the Global South” In preparation to be submitted to *Sociological Theory* (Special Issue on Global Theory).
- 7) Summers-Effler, Erika, **Matthew Coetzee**, Stephanie Israel, and Simone Polillo. “Nuance, Transposability, and Creativity: How Perception Produces the Potential for Social Change.” In preparation to be submitted to *American Journal of Sociology*.

Works in Progress

- 8) **Coetzee, Matthew**. “Perceptual Aperture Dynamics: Cognition and Cultural Responses to Disruption and Stability.” Manuscript in preparation for *Sociological Theory*.
- 9) **Coetzee, Matthew**. “Structural Integration at Elite Universities: Symbolic Boundary Making of Pan-African Identity” Manuscript in preparation for *American Journal of Cultural Sociology*.
- 10) **Coetzee, Matthew**. “Protest Performance and Strategic Misalignment: Solidarity, Audience, and the Limits of Mobilization in Hong Kong” Manuscript in preparation for *Mobilization*.

PRESENTATIONS

American Sociological Association Annual Meeting, Panel Discussion , Chicago, USA	2025
<i>"Rupture, Repair, and the Civil Sphere: Moral Solidarity and Dynamics of Perception in Post-Apartheid South Africa"</i>	
CBSM: On the Many Impacts of Social Movements , Northwestern University, Chicago, USA	2025
<i>"Contingent Memory Activation and Civil Repair: Collective Memory and Crisis Response"</i>	
Civil Sphere Theory Working Group , University of Vienna, Vienna, Austria	2025
<i>"Eventful Sociology and Civil Sphere Theory: Resisting Unrest in Post-Apartheid South Africa"</i>	
Social Science History Association Annual Meeting , Culture Network, Chicago, USA	2025
<i>"Rupture, Repair, and the Civil Sphere: Moral Solidarity and Dynamics of Perception"</i>	
Democracy, Autocracy and Protest: Social Movements in Times of Crisis , San Diego, USA	2025
<i>"Contingent Memory Activation and Civil Repair: Collective Memory and Crisis Response"</i>	
American Sociological Association Annual Meeting, Panel Discussion , Montréal, Canada	2024

"Adhocracies, Collective Memory, and Cohesion Amidst Civil Unrest in Post-Apartheid South Africa"

University of Notre Dame, Rome Global Gateway, Rome, Italy 2023

"Has Christianity Become Obsolete? Shifts in Deep Culture and Young Adult Indifference"

Civil Sphere Theory Working Group, University of Trento, Trento, Italy 2021

"Founding Moments and Civil Repair," Lyn Spillman with Matthew Coetzee and Isaac Kimmel

GRANTS & FELLOWSHIPS

Wilsey Distinguished Graduate Fellowship, \$44,000	2025 – 2026
Pre-Doctoral Fellow, Center for Cultural Sociology, Yale University	2025 – Present
Kellogg Institute Fellow, \$6,000 annually	2021 – Present
Institute of Arts and Letters: Technology and the Common Good Research Grant, \$4,300	2024
Kellogg Institute Graduate Research Grant, \$3,750	2022
Sorin Fellow, de Nicola Center for Ethics and Culture	2021 – Present
Yale-China Fellowship, \$15,000	2018 – 2020

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Teaching Assistant, University of Notre Dame 2021 – Present

Foundations of Sociological Theory (SOC 34090)

Kinship on the Margins: Encountering Poverty and the Catholic Social Tradition (PS 30600)

Confronting Social Issues: International (THEO 33938)

Research on American Cultural Change and Secularization I & II (SOC 40966 & 44966)

U.S. Change & Secularization III (SOC 43966)

Marriage and the Family (SOC 20342)

ADDITIONAL RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Project Manager 2022 – 2024

Professor Christian Smith, University of Notre Dame

Why Religion Went Obsolete: The Demise of Traditional Faith in America, Oxford University Press

- Managed a team of six undergraduate researchers conducting and coding 200+ in-depth interviews
- Led data coding and thematic analysis of interviewees' religious life histories
- Compiled appendices and selected quotations for the published book
- Mentees progressed into careers in academia, counseling, education, consulting, and university administration

Graduate Research Assistant 2021 – 2022

Professor Lyn Spillman, University of Notre Dame

- Assisted with research for "Founding Moments and Civil Repair" invited talk on the 1619 Project & America 250 Projects at the Civil Sphere Working Group

Pre-Doctoral Research Assistant, Yale-China Fellowship 2019 – 2021
Professor Andrew Junker, Chinese University of Hong Kong
• Conducted research on the Anti-Extradition Bill (“Antielab”) protests, focusing on protest dramaturgy and social movement dynamics in Hong Kong

PROFESSIONAL WORK EXPERIENCE

NTK Academic Group, Hong Kong, HK 2020 – 2021
Instructor, English and Humanities Department
• Taught English and Humanities at Hong Kong’s leading academic group for international curricula
• Developed and published academic course materials, including *Writing for Academic Achievement*, *Literary Analysis and Commentary*, and *Standardized Test Preparation*

Yale-China Association, Changsha, China 2018 – 2020
Yale-China Fellow
• Continued a 120+ year tradition of cross-cultural engagement through education and healthcare initiatives in mainland China
• Established new Yale-China education initiatives in Western Hunan in partnership with local NGOs
• Taught English at Yali High School, a Yale-China partner institution and one of the oldest U.S.–China educational collaborations
• Co-directed a bilingual student production of *Into the Woods*
• Mentored students in U.S. college admissions, two of whom matriculated to Stanford and NYU

PROFESSIONAL AFFILIATIONS

American Sociological Association: Theory, Culture, Social Movements and Collective Behavior
Social Science History Association
Civil Sphere Theory Working Group
Center for Cultural Sociology, Yale University

SERVICE AND COMMUNITY ENGAGEMENT

University of Notre Dame, Indiana, USA
Ethnography Workshop Coordinator 2024 – Present
Founding Member, Friends at Midnight, Catholic LGBTQ+ Faith Group 2024
Graduate Student Volunteer, Open Search Committee 2024
Volunteer Coordinator, St. Augustine’s Church Soup Kitchen 2023 – Present

Yale University, Connecticut, USA
Associate Fellow, Yale Young African Scholars Program, Rwanda & Zimbabwe 2017 – 2018
• Facilitated college-prep seminars on social enterprise, religion, and politics for high-achieving, low-income students from over 30 African countries
• Provided year-long mentorship on SAT prep, application strategy, and U.S. college essays

Yale Chaplaincy Fellow, Yale Chaplain's Office, New Haven, CT 2016 – 2017

- Organized four campus-wide events exploring religious pluralism, purpose, and interfaith engagement
- Participated in a service-learning trip to Washington, D.C., volunteering with the World Food Bank and engaging with diverse local faith communities

Political Chair (2016) & Outreach Chair (2015), Yale African Students' Association 2015 – 2016

- Served on the executive board, advocating for the social and political representation of African students
- Lead planner for *Africa Week*, managing guest travel, programming, and funding logistics
- Launched “African Connections,” a cross-diasporic dialogue series among African, Caribbean, and African-American students on race, identity, and belonging

Inclusion Council Member, Yale International Students' Organization 2016

- Co-authored a policy report on international student well-being, focusing on financial aid
- Resulted in stronger mental health support and more transparent aid processes

Hillcrest AIDS Centre Trust, KwaZulu-Natal, South Africa

Volunteer Research Assistant

2016

- Designed an educational impact survey for 8,000 rural youth across KwaZulu-Natal
- Analyzed outcomes used to secure international donor funding for youth empowerment and HIV prevention programming

SKILLS

Research Methods: Qualitative Interviewing, Thematic Coding, Case Study Analysis, Comparative-Historical Methods, Visual Content Analysis, Survey Design, Social Network Analysis (R), Grounded Theory

Digital Tools & Programming: R, Stata, Gephi, ArcGIS, Atlas.ti, NVivo

Languages: English (Native), Afrikaans (Working Proficiency), Mandarin (Limited Working Proficiency), Zulu (Conversational Proficiency)

REFERENCES

Ann Mische

University of Notre Dame

Associate Professor of Sociology and Peace Studies

Email: Ann.E.Mische.2@nd.edu

Philip Smith

Yale University

Professor of Sociology

Email: philip.smith@yale.edu

Christian Smith

University of Notre Dame

William R. Kenan, Jr. Professor of Sociology

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Lyn Spillman

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Emeritus Professor of Sociology

Email: spillman.1@nd.edu

Erika Summers-Effler

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Associate Professor of Sociology

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